equivocated on the subject or remained silent on whether it would commit to such plans. This approach, as well as denials that Delhi had promised Moscow any basing rights, had the dual benefit of signaling not only China but also the US that India was not just a camp follower of the Soviet Union.[59]

Until the mid-1970s, there were mixed signals from China, with Beijing "blowing hot and cold." Indian policymakers watched for positive signs. They speculated about what might induce Beijing to react positively to Indian overtures: changes in Chinese domestic politics, Sino-Soviet rapprochement, or even a Chinese desire to show the international community that it was being magnanimous. After 1975, there were a few more signals from China. In another installment of ping-pong diplomacy, Beijing sent a table tennis team to India in January 1975. In February, at a stopover in Calcutta, the Chinese vice premier announced Chinese openness to a dialogue. That winter, officials noticed that China did not denounce India at the UN as it did routinely.[60]

India still had concerns about China. Indian policymakers told US officials that they did not expect China to attack India. However, as US assessments indicated, Indian officials remained "wary and sensitive" about the possibility. As the Indian Foreign Minister Swaran Singh had explained to Kissinger, "Because of 1962 we have to be careful."[61] There continued to be incidents that caused concern at the boundary, including the killing of Indian soldiers. China's support to Indian insurgents also persisted. Indian officials were, furthermore, anxious that Beijing would move from exploiting difficulties between India and its neighbors to creating them. China continued to help Pakistan, including with its nuclear program after India's 1974 peaceful nuclear explosion. Delhi also worried about growing Chinese and Pakistani influence in Bangladesh, especially after a military coup and the assassination of President Mujibur Rehman in summer 1975. Furthermore, Indian policymakers were concerned about Chinese influence in Bhutan, and China's nonrecognition of the Indian takeover of Sikkim. China also continued to aid and support Nepal and conduct anti-India propaganda there. Even beyond the neighborhood, India watched with concern China's efforts to woo other nonaligned countries.[62]

There was no consensus on the importance of improving relations with China in the Indian government. There were also disagreements about how